

FRIDAY, JUNE 5, 2026

The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

₹7.00 (₹8 RAIPUR, ₹15 SRINAGAR) • www.indianexpress.com

NEW DELHI, LATE CITY, 22 PAGES

ATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI, NAGPUR, PATNA, PUNJAB

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 05~06~2026

:-FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You

Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination. There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

ACTING PRESIDENT ON INDIA VISIT

Venezuela, India in talks for long-term energy pacts



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Venezuela's Acting President Delcy Rodriguez in New Delhi on Thursday. ANIL SHARMA

Rodriguez, Modi hold discussions; tech team to go to Venezuela: Puri

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 4

INDIA AND Venezuela Thursday discussed "forging an energy partnership" and entering into "long-term contracts" as Delcy Rodriguez, on her first trip to India after becoming Acting President of her country, held talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi in New Delhi.

Rodriguez took charge of Venezuela after President Nicolas Maduro was abducted by US forces in a military operation in January this year. After meeting Rodriguez, Modi, in a post on X, said, "We had extensive discussions on expanding our cooperation in energy, critical minerals, technology, agriculture, health and people-to-people ties."

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Army chief: Accelerating absorption of drones, better command systems

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, June 4

UNDERLINING THAT the Indian Army has accelerated the absorption of drones, UAVs, loitering munitions and counter-UAS systems in a structured manner, Army chief General Upendra Dwivedi said Thursday that the larger aim of the Army is not merely to procure drones, but to absorb them into the way the Army trains, operates and fights.

In an interview with *The Indian Express*, General Dwivedi said the procurement and in-



General Upendra Dwivedi

duction of drones cover a wide range of capabilities, that the Army is also introducing better command and control arrangements for a drone-dense battle-

field, including a Unified Control Centre at division levels to manage the growing number of UAS and C-UAS systems at the tactical level.

General Dwivedi is set to retire as the Army chief at the end of this month. Much of the Army's accelerated move towards procuring and inducting drones, unmanned aerial systems, loitering munitions and counter-drone capabilities have gathered pace during his tenure in the last two years. Various structures, procedures and command systems needed

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

India, Venezuela

“As a valued partner in Latin America, our close cooperation with Venezuela holds immense importance for the Global South. We will continue to work together for the mutual benefit of the people of our nations,” he said.

Asked whether the leaders discussed the issue of Maduro, Rudrendra Tandon, Secretary (East) in the Ministry of External Affairs, said, “Coming to the political transition, of course, this was a very frank conversation that the two leaders had, both during when all of us were there, as well as on the table when they were having their working lunch, but I don’t think that I should, you know, get into those sort of things.”

“We all know that there was a transition in Venezuela. But we are working with a government that is friendly, that wants a partnership with India. We want to reciprocate that, and don’t forget that Venezuela has been traditionally a very close friend. Bilaterally, we have done a lot of partnerships, and at the international level, we have collaborated very closely... We are just going back to normal,” he said.

Tandon said Venezuela views India as a “preferred partner” and “India has stood with Venezuela in bad times as well as in good times”.

On the energy relationship between India and Venezuela, he said, “Venezuela possesses one of the largest oil reserves in the world. The Indian economy is a large and growing consumer of oil and will have a stable demand growth for many years to come. Thus, in the energy sector, we see a perfect complementarity. In fact, in our spot purchases, Venezuela has already emerged as the third largest supplier this month, so quite naturally today’s discussions focused on forging an energy partnership.”

“It is in their interest to enter into long-term contracts rather

than to do spot buying. So we hope that at some stage we move forward to long-term secure supplies from all our suppliers,” he said.

With Venezuela’s energy sector undergoing a massive restructuring where major reforms are being implemented to open both the oil and electricity markets to private capital, Tandon said, “We are not going into details of the conversation. What did emerge from the interaction of the two leaders was that the Venezuelan energy sector is undergoing a fundamental transformation... There exists a perfect complementarity for India and Venezuela to work in the energy sector both upstream as well as downstream.”

“The discussion on the energy sector was extensive. The talk of partnership was not just buyer-seller, it was participation of Indian companies upstream and downstream in all its aspects. Of course, the details of this cannot be worked out at the Prime Minister level. This will have to be taken up by the companies themselves, but the message that came across very clearly from the Venezuelan side is that they are open for business, they are reforming their industry, so there are great opportunities for India. And our response to that was that we are willing, our companies are willing, and we will take steps to facilitate that as a government.”

“But ultimately, it is a commercial decision that Indian companies in the energy sector will have to take on the discounts. Payments will be done in the way the companies want. The Government of India, because of the developments in the Middle East, is aggressively seeking out new sources of crude oil and energy to ensure India’s energy security. So, Venezuela is an opportunity, and it is very much part of our plan”, he said.

Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri, who called on Rodriguez along with ministry offi-

cials and CMDs of energy PSUs, said, “India has a long standing energy partnership with Venezuela since 2008 and shares unique complementarities with the country.”

“Venezuela possesses the biggest proven reserves of oil in the world, while India not only possesses huge demand for energy but also has the technological expertise and manpower to refine Venezuelan crude in our refineries,” he said in a post on X.

Venezuela, Puri said, was among the largest crude oil suppliers to India in April and May this year, “a reflection of the future potential”. He said an Indian technical team will visit Venezuela soon to “further explore this potential”.

According to Tandon, the two sides also discussed cooperation in areas including critical minerals, gold and diamond mining, animal husbandry, transportation, agriculture equipment, automotive sector, and pharmaceuticals.

“Pharmaceuticals was discussed in quite a lot of detail, particularly the ability of Indian manufacturers to provide high quality generic drugs at low cost to their public health services, which is a very important part. In fact, this was listed by the Venezuelan delegation as one of the priority areas, so much so that the Prime Minister actually directed that one of her ministers, who is accompanying her, should be exposed to our entire Jan Ausadhi scheme.”

Accompanying Rodriguez is a ministerial delegation that includes ministers of foreign affairs, communication and information, economy and finance, science and technology, and the transportation.

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, who also called on Rodriguez, later said, “Deeply value her longstanding commitment to the India-Venezuela relationship.”

Rodriguez, who has been to India at least six times in the past, is expected to travel to Ahmedabad, Bengaluru and Mumbai.

Accelerating drone absorption, better command and control systems: Army chief

to absorb them into the force have also been set up during this time.

Declining to comment on the numbers and the cost of the drones procured by the Army, he said what is important is the absorption of drones, UAVs, loitering munitions and counter-UAS systems in a structured manner.

A wide range of capabilities, he said, have been bought and inducted, including micro and mini-UAVs for units, tactical drones for surveillance and target acquisition, logistics drones for difficult terrain, high-altitude surveillance platforms, loitering munitions for precision engagement, and counter-UAS systems such as sensors, jammers, spoofers and soft-kill and hard-kill options.

“Our approach is tiered, role-based and terrain-specific. At the infantry battalion level, Ashni drone platoons are being integrated to provide organic surveillance, target acquisition and tactical awareness. This will give the soldier and small team their own aerial awareness and tactical reach, an idea we have described as ‘Eagle on the Arm’,” he said.

“At the formation level, larger UAVs, loitering munitions and counter-UAS systems are being linked with artillery, air defence, aviation, intelligence and electronic warfare grids,” he said, adding that the aim is to shorten the sensor-to-shooter cycle and give commanders real-time battlefield awareness.

General Dwivedi said the Shaktibaan Regiments and Divyastra Batteries of the Army are also part of this restructuring in the Regiment of Artillery. “They will strengthen unmanned and counter-unmanned capability, precision targeting and protection against hostile drone threats. The larger aim is not merely to procure drones, but to absorb them in the way the Army trains, operates and fights,” he said.

“We are also introducing better command and control arrangements for the drone-dense battlefield. The concept of a Unified Control Centre (UCC) at division levels has been introduced to manage the growing number of UAS and C-UAS systems at the tactical level,” he said, adding that this will help in coordination, de-confliction, tasking and optimum employment of unmanned assets.

Responding to a question on the broader changes in the Army based on lessons from Operation Sindoor and ongoing global conflicts, he said it has reinforced the belief that future conflicts will be multi-domain, technology-intensive, fast-paced and increasingly transparent.

“The lessons are being incorporated into doctrine, training, exercises, SOPs, procure-

ment priorities and force structuring,” he said.

He said the focus areas of the Army’s capability-based approach include multi-sensor surveillance, drones, loitering munitions, counter-UAS systems, long-range precision fires, air defence, cyber, electronic warfare, secure communications and AI-enabled decision-support systems.

Operation Sindoor, he said, also validated the importance of integrated planning, real-time intelligence fusion, secure communications, precision weapons, drones, loitering munitions and compressed decision cycles.

“It reinforced the need for faster R&D, better quality systems, timely delivery and stronger integration among air defence, artillery, aviation, intelligence and electronic warfare assets,” he said.

Similarly, global conflicts have also shown that drones are not only platforms but consumables. “Therefore, inventory depth, modular designs, rapid repair chains and assured component supply are important. This strengthens the case for Atmanirbharta, because Indian solutions are required for Indian terrain, threats and operational conditions.”

Alongside technology, he said, the Army is strengthening mobility, survivability, logistics, surveillance architecture and communication networks to support faster mobilisation and sustained operations.

“Deployment postures are being kept flexible and balanced so that formations remain prepared for both short, high-intensity operations and longer contingencies. The larger aim is to make the Army more agile, networked, integrated and adaptive,” he said.

Asked about possible tweaks in the Agnipath scheme, General Dwivedi said the scheme should be seen as a major manpower reform aimed at making the Army younger, more energetic, disciplined and future-ready.

“The character of warfare is changing rapidly, and we need soldiers who are not only physically fit, but also technology-aware and capable of adapting quickly to drones, surveillance systems, secure communication networks, electronic warfare and modern battlefield tools,” he said, adding that Agniveers are making a positive contribution to the Army.

At the same time, the scheme, he said, is an evolutionary process. “The full cycle of the first batch is yet to be completed, and therefore it would be premature to arrive at a conclusion,” he said, adding that any decision on tweaks or refinements should be based on time, experience, operational feedback and institutional assessment.

‘India reliable partner’: Putin blasts Western interference in Moscow-Delhi relations

Press Trust of India
St Petersburg, June 4

RUSSIAN PRESIDENT Vladimir Putin on Thursday hailed Moscow’s strategic partnership with New Delhi and asserted that Western attempts to force India into scaling back its cooperation with Russia are futile and damaging to global stability.

In an interaction with heads of leading global news agencies including PTI, Putin lauded India’s economic growth and its independent foreign policy and said Russia is determined to expand its economic engagement with the nation. “India is among the world’s major economies and is demonstrating an impressive rate of economic growth,” Putin remarked, expressing confidence that bilateral trade between the two nations is on track to hit a USD 100 billion milestone in the coming years.

“India is one of the leading

economies of the world that has showed the highest rate of economic growth. This is not something that comes out of the blue. This is result of the hard work that the government of India has been doing under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi,” Putin said.

“We are glad that India is developing its relations with all countries it thinks important for its national interests,” Putin said when asked whether India’s deep alignment with Washington creates structural friction for Russia. At the same time the Russian president added that there have been Western attempts to put pressure on when it comes to cooperation with Russia. “Everyone has understood that pressure on PM Narendra Modi and India is detrimental for international ties.”

Putin said Russia considers India as a “reliable partner”.



Agri Stack, e-Jagriti, Mahakumbh 2025 among winners of e-governance award

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 4

THE UNION government on Thursday named 16 projects of the Central, state and local governments across the country as the winners of the National Awards for e-Governance. These include the Agriculture Ministry's platform for farmers, known as Agri Stack; the Consumer Affairs Ministry's e-Jagriti platform for filing complaints; and the Prayagraj Mela Authority's conduct of the Mahakumbh 2025.

Ten projects would be given the Gold Award while six would be handed out the Silver Award during a ceremony on July 2.

“National Awards for e-Governance are presented every year to recognise and promote excellence in implementation of e-Governance initiatives. The 29th NAEg 2026 awardees in seven categories include the gram panchayats category, recognising deepening and widening of service delivery at grassroots level through digitisation,” the Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions said in a statement.

The Agriculture Ministry's Agri Stack provides data to farmers with regard to finance

Ten projects would be given the Gold Award while six would be handed out the Silver Award during a ceremony on July 2

as well as early warning systems for disasters. The e-Jagriti portal allows consumers to lodge complaints regarding insurance, banking, housing, electricity, finance, medical care, automobiles etc. The 2025 Mahakumbh in Prayagraj had seen deployment of e-governance initiatives, apart from physical infrastructure.

The awardees include the Kerala Development and Innovation Strategic Council's initiative for making blood donation easier through a "blood bag traceability and citizen interaction portal".

The Union Ministry of Health and Family Welfare's AI-enabled clinical decision support system in its eSanjeevani telemedicine service was also among the winners. The Kerala High Court's district court case management system would also be given an award.

CONFLICT SPARKS SHORTAGE OF 2 COMMON CHEMOTHERAPY DRUGS

Chemo patients bear the brunt of war in West Asia

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, June 4

TWO COMMONLY used, affordable chemotherapy medicines — Cisplatin and Carboplatin — have gone off the shelves across the country over the last two weeks, prompting oncologists to raise an alarm. This is because of the increase in prices of raw materials, fuelled by the Hormuz crisis, and the inability of companies to raise prices since they are under the government’s price control ambit, according to industry experts.

“Our hospital pharmacy has run out of Cisplatin and Carboplatin. Nearly seven in 10 patients in my clinic need one of these drugs. They are prescribed for oral, lung, cervical, oesophageal, ovarian, and breast cancer, among others. Now, we have cancer patients running from one store to the other in search of this medicine. My colleagues in other cities are also facing a similar situation,” said Dr Shyam Agarwal, chairman of medical oncology at Sir Gangaram Hospital.

Dr Abhishek Shankar, oncologist from the All India Institute

“This precious metal (all platinum-derived chemotherapy agents) was trading at Rs 2,700 per gram in mid-2023 but has now skyrocketed to over Rs 7,800 per gram”

DR MOHAN MENON,
MEDICAL ONCOLOGIST AT LILAVATI HOSPITAL AND RESEARCH CENTRE, MUMBAI

of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), New Delhi, echoed a similar concern: “There has been a shortage of these drugs for at least the last two weeks.” Another Delhi-based oncologist said that lower doses have completely gone off the shelves though higher doses are still available in some stores.

In Mumbai, Dr Mohan Menon, medical oncologist at Lilavati Hospital and Research Centre, said that there has been a shortage of all platinum-derived chemotherapy agents, adding the root cause of the failure

“Our hospital pharmacy has run out of Cisplatin and Carboplatin... They are prescribed for oral, lung, cervical, oesophageal, ovarian, and breast cancer, among others...”

DR SHYAM AGARWAL,
CHAIRMAN OF MEDICAL ONCOLOGY AT SIR GANGARAM HOSPITAL, NEW DELHI

is the increase in prices of platinum globally. “This precious metal was trading at Rs 2,700 per gram in mid-2023 but has now skyrocketed to over Rs 7,800 per gram,” he said. Wholesalers and stockists, meanwhile, are fast running out of supplies. The owner of a major retail pharmacy in Delhi said: “Almost no medical store in the country has these medicines at the moment. Most stockists and wholesalers have run out of them. With the limited stock they have, they are saying they will sell it directly to

patients instead of retailers.”

While the increasing cost of raw materials has elevated prices of many medical products, especially those based on petrochemicals, since the start of the war, the companies producing these two drugs have maintained the prices. These medicines come under Drug Pricing Control Order (DPCO), which regulates the prices of all essential medicines in the country. Any drug under the DPCO can only increase its price in tandem with the average rise in wholesale prices each year.

While the prices of platinum have been going up — owing to a deficit in the world’s largest supplier, South Africa, and the growing usage of the metal in the automotive sector besides in production of green hydrogen — the current West Asia crisis has added fuel to the fire. “Most of India’s platinum is imported from Gulf countries, which have been impacted due to the current conflict,” said an industry expert, who did not wish to be named. United Arab Emirates is the biggest supplier of platinum for India, accounting for nearly half the imports.

Tata Memorial study finds radiation cuts bladder cancer recurrence risk by over 50%

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, June 4

A MAJOR clinical trial led by Tata Memorial Hospital (TMH), Mumbai, and conducted across four Indian cancer centres over eight years has found that radiation therapy after bladder removal surgery can reduce the risk of cancer returning to the pelvis by more than half.

The findings of the Bladder Adjuvant Radiotherapy (BART) trial were recently published in the ‘Journal of Clinical Oncology,’ one of the world’s leading cancer research journals. “When bladder cancer recurs in the pelvis, treatment options are limited and survival is often measured in months. Our study shows that radiation after bladder removal surgery can significantly reduce the risk of pelvic recurrence with manageable side effects,” said Dr Vedang Murthy, professor, Department of Radiation Oncology, Tata Memorial Centre, and lead investigator of the BART trial.

Bladder cancer is among the most difficult and expensive cancers to diagnose and treat. According to the International Agency for Research on Cancer

(IARC), it is the ninth most common cancer worldwide. More than six lakh people were diagnosed with the disease globally in 2022. In India, data from the Global Cancer Observatory (2022) estimates around 22,548 new cases and 12,353 deaths annually, making it the country’s 17th most common cancer. The disease disproportionately affects men, with tobacco consumption among the major risk factors.

Muscle-invasive bladder cancer is a particularly aggressive form of the disease. Standard treatment typically involves chemotherapy followed by surgical removal of the bladder and surrounding organs, including the prostate in men or uterus in women, along with nearby lymph nodes. Patients then undergo reconstructive procedures to create an alternative pathway for urine after bladder removal.

“Patients go through extensive treatment, yet nearly two-thirds develop recurrent disease within three years,” said Dr Murthy. “Some recurrences occur in distant organs such as the lungs or bones. However, in roughly a quarter of high-risk patients, the cancer returns in

the pelvis where the bladder was originally located. These relapses are especially devastating because there are very few effective treatment options once they occur. This is the challenge we set out to address.”

The BART trial enrolled 153 patients, who had undergone surgery for bladder cancer. Half the participants received radiation therapy to the pelvis after surgery, while the remaining patients were placed under observation.

“The results were clear. Radiation reduced the risk of cancer returning to the pelvis by more than 50 per cent,” Dr Murthy said. In the trial, fewer than five per cent of patients experienced severe side effects, while most treatment-related symptoms were temporary and improved after therapy ended.

The significance of the study extends beyond India. While immunotherapy drugs such as nivolumab and pembrolizumab have shown benefits in reducing recurrence, their high cost remains a major barrier in many parts of the world.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

New Delhi, June 4

Jaishankar, who met Cooper on her first visit to India as Foreign Secretary, said, "We reviewed ongoing progress in our cooperation focusing on trade, technology, supply chains, defence, climate, education and people to people ties. Also spoke about new op-



Foreign Minister S Jaishankar
with UK Foreign Secretary
Yvette Cooper in New Delhi. PTI

Earlier, at the bilateral meeting, Jaishankar said that India and the UK are well-positioned to construct a new future-oriented and mutually beneficial partnership on the back of their newly firm-up comprehensive trade deal and the defence industrial roadmap.

Highlighting the finalisation of India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement, Jaishankar said CETA addresses many concerns about creating resilient supply chains and addressing concerns in areas of trade, energy, food and economic security.

SC panel proposes ban on AI use to decide verdicts, judge bail risks

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, June 4

A COMPLETE ban on using artificial intelligence (AI) to decide judicial outcomes; restrictions on AI tools that predict or profile parties and witnesses; and a prohibition on undisclosed or unexplainable AI systems in court processes—these are among the draft regulations proposed by the Supreme Court AI Committee on the use of the technology in courts. The preliminary draft of the ‘Regulations for Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in Courts, 2026’ published by the top court on Wednesday emphasises that the use of AI in court processes will always “remain strictly subservient to human judgment and judicial authority”.

Every AI system, it says, will function solely in an assistive capacity and "shall not supplant or compromise the independent exercise of judicial authority by a duly appointed judicial officer" and "the ultimate authority to determine matters of law, fact and justice shall vest exclusively in the judicial officers of the competent jurisdiction".

The committee — chaired by Supreme Court judge Justice P S Narasimha, and including Justices Sanjeev Sachdeva, Raja Vijayraghavan V, Anoop

***The use of AI in court
will remain strictly
subservient to
human judgement &
judicial authority,
says committee***

Chitkara, and Suraj Govindaraj as members—has now sought the views and suggestions of all stakeholders and the general public on the draft recommendations before finalising them. The suggestions have to be submitted by June 20.

As per the draft, AI systems used in court processes “shall be designed, trained and deployed in a manner that promotes fairness and avoids discrimination”. “No AI System shall be deployed that perpetuates, amplifies, or introduces bias on the grounds of race, religion, caste, sex, gender, disability, language, economic status, or any other ground prohibited under the Constitution or any law for the time being in force and special care shall be taken to protect the rights and interests of vulnerable groups including women, children, persons with disabilities, marginalised and minority communities, and persons from economically and socially disad-

vantaged backgrounds," it adds.

The systems will be subject to the provisions of the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023.

Permissible uses of AI include for case management, cause list preparation, hearing scheduling, transcription of court proceedings, translation of judgments etc, legal research, administrative functions including case filing assistance, defect scrutiny, record management and judicial resource allocation, conversational AI assistants and guided chatbots to assist litigants and other stakeholders in accessing court services and understanding procedural requirements, accessibility services for persons with disabilities or language barriers and anonymisation of court records,

Among the prohibitions, the draft says that no personal data of any person shall be used to train, test, or refine any AI system without the prior approval of the appropriate authority, or to perform the function of adjudication or sentencing in any matter without mandatory human-in-the-loop. It added that any output of an AI system in relation to adjudicative or sentencing questions shall be treated as advisory only and will be subject to independent judicial evaluation.

The proposal says that “no AI system shall be used for risk scoring for any purpose in court processes, including the assessment of flight risk, prediction of recidivism, evaluation of bail eligibility, or determination of the credibility of parties or witnesses” and that “no undisclosed, opaque, or unexplainable AI system shall be used in any court process that may materially affect the lawful rights or personal liberty of any party.”

The apex body, it recommends, would include two SC judges nominated by the CJI, one of whom shall serve as ex-officio chairperson; two high court Chief Justices nominated by the CJI; two high court judges nominated by the CJI; one member from an institution of national importance or any institution of repute, as may be nominated by the CJI; an officer not below the rank of joint secretary to the Government of India in the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology; a finance expert, to be nominated by the CJI; a cybersecurity expert, to be nominated by the CJI; one or more advocates of standing, nominated by the CJI with expertise in technology related laws or data privacy or related fields; and the professor heading the field of AI at the NJAP.

The Editorial Page

FRIDAY, JUNE 5, 2026

Trump tariff saga goes on, India must find way

ON TUESDAY, the US Trade Representative proposed tariffs on 60 countries under Section 301 of the US Trade Act, 1974 — economies that together account for 99.4 per cent of all US imports. That the proposal has come up now — the USTR will hold hearings on the proposed actions on July 7 — is no accident. After the US court struck down the policy of reciprocal tariffs brought through the International Emergency Economic Powers Act, Trump had imposed a 10 per cent levy on all trading partners through Section 122 of the Trade Act. This tariff could, however, be levied only for a maximum of 150 days, unless extended by the US Congress. That period will end on July 24. The USTR's investigation and its proposals now create space for White House to move ahead with its trade agenda.

Of the 60 countries, 54 are said to have failed "to impose a legal prohibition on the importation of goods" that have been produced by forced labour and have allegedly been unable "to effectively enforce such a prohibition". This category includes a wide range of countries — from China and India to Saudi Arabia, Australia, Switzerland, the UK, and others. Another six countries — EU, Canada, Indonesia, Mexico, Ecuador, and Pakistan — are said to have "failed to effectively enforce a forced labour import prohibition". The USTR has proposed two sets of tariffs — 10 per cent and 12.5 per cent. India falls in the latter category. However, this is not all. Attempts to reinforce the tariff wall are playing out across multiple arenas. Another investigation was launched in March to look into the issue of "structural excess capacity and production in manufacturing sectors" of 16 economies, including countries like India and China. All this suggests that, despite judicial setbacks, tariffs will likely remain key to the Trump agenda.

The Indian government has responded to the USTR's proposals by saying that it is engaging with the US on the issue, while also working towards finalising the framework agreement announced by the two countries earlier this year. On Wednesday, Sergio Gor, the US Ambassador to India, said that the negotiations had mostly wrapped up, with only a few points still to be ironed out. As India moves forward with its trade deal with the US, it must be mindful of the unpredictable nature of the White House administration. It should press for greater market access while safeguarding its interests.

This World Environment Day, let's broaden the conversation



PURVI MEHTA

WORLD ENVIRONMENT Day is an occasion to reflect on the growing threat posed by climate change. Recent weather extremes in Delhi — from 43°C heat to torrential rain and sharp temperature swings within days — underscore the growing unpredictability of our climate. The planet has already warmed by more than 1.1°C above pre-industrial levels, and its impacts are being felt across the world.

Climate-related disasters now inflict economic losses of roughly US\$300-320 billion annually worldwide, significantly above long-term averages, with weather-related events accounting for more than 90 per cent of the damage. Key sectors like agriculture are coming under pressure from heat stress, droughts, floods, and shifting pest dynamics. Water scarcity already affects billions, while infrastructure designed for the 20th century is increasingly unfit for today's realities.

These challenges are creating unprecedented demand for recalibrations of technologies, resilient infrastructure, climate-smart manufacturing, water-efficient systems and innovative business models. The climate crisis is becoming one of the most powerful drivers of economic transformation in modern history. The world is now entering what is being called the "adaptation economy". Recent industry estimates place the global climate adaptation market at roughly US\$30-35 billion in 2025, encompassing climate-resilient infrastructure, water management systems, early-warning technologies, resilient agriculture, cooling technologies, climate analytics, and adaptation services. It is expected to grow to US\$95-140 billion by 2030 with an annual growth rate of roughly 10-16 per cent.

It offers a high return on investment. According to the Global Commission on Adaptation, investing \$1.8 trillion globally in climate adaptation by 2030 could generate more than \$7 trillion in net economic benefits. Meanwhile, the United Nations estimates that adaptation investment needs in developing countries could exceed \$300 billion annually by 2030 and rise further thereafter. These figures represent not merely costs of adaptation but opportunities for innovation, entrepreneurship, job creation and economic growth.

For India, the opportunity is significant. The country has committed to achieving net-zero emissions by 2070 while simulta-

neously pursuing rapid economic growth. According to NITI Aayog, it will require cumulative investments of approximately US\$22.7 trillion by 2070 to achieve its net-zero target. This is roughly US\$500 billion annually for the next four-and-a-half decades. This dual objective, often framed as a challenge, can equally be viewed as an economic opportunity.

India is already among the world's fastest-growing renewable energy markets. Its ambitious targets in solar energy, green hydrogen, battery manufacturing, electric vehicles, sustainable mobility and energy-efficient infrastructure have the potential to attract hundreds of billions of dollars in investment. The transition to a low-carbon economy could create millions of new jobs across the manufacturing, engineering, construction, digital services and energy management sectors. India has many of the ingredients required to become a global hub for climate solutions: Entrepreneurial talent, engineering capability, a large domestic market and a growing innovation ecosystem.

Agriculture, a crucial sector, is also the one most directly exposed to climate variability, requiring an entirely new generation of climate-resilient seeds, stress-tolerant varieties, irrigation infrastructure, cold storage, and thermostable vaccines. These are no longer scientific pursuits — they are major commercial opportunities. The same opportunity exists in infrastructure. There is now a vast market for climate-resilient construction materials, advanced cooling systems, water management technologies, climate-appropriate transportation systems and resilient urban planning. None of this reduces the urgency of climate action. Adaptation is not a substitute for mitigation. Reducing greenhouse gas emissions remains critical to avoid the consequences of climate change.

But this World Environment Day, perhaps we should broaden the conversation. The question is no longer whether the climate is changing. The question is how to adapt to it and optimise investments in building technologies, businesses and industries needed to make adaptation a driver of economic growth. Countries that view climate change as both a challenge and an opportunity will build the industries, create the jobs, and shape the economies of the future. India has every reason to be among them.

The writer is senior industry policy advisor. Views are personal

The junta in Myanmar is not a partner India needs



RO DING

INDIA RECEIVED General Min Aung Hlaing with the honours of a head of state. He came to New Delhi seeking legitimacy, and he left after giving almost nothing in return. He repeated the assurance that Myanmar's territory would not be permitted to be used against India's security interests. That is a promise the junta has already broken by making common cause with anti-India insurgents to fight the people of Myanmar.

Min Aung Hlaing is not the country's legitimate leader in any sense. The election he organised earlier this year was held in less than half the country. The parties that won the 2020 election in a landslide were barred from contesting, and the leaders who won it, including Aung San Suu Kyi, remain in prison or have been killed. This is why the United Nations lists U Win Myint and Daw Aung San Suu Kyi, not Min Aung Hlaing, as Myanmar's head of state and foreign minister. Recent efforts by the junta regime to feign reform are hollow. Aung San Suu Kyi was reportedly moved from prison to "house arrest" last month, but the regime has done nothing to address concerns raised by her son about whether she is still alive. Just four days after the junta took power, it bombed a Buddhist monastery. Min Aung Hlaing's new "civillian" cabinet is composed of 24 former generals. These are not signs of reform.

India shares a 1,643-km border with Myanmar across four northeastern states, and it must be pragmatic. But legitimising the military junta is self-harm. A government partner is only as useful to India as its ability to deliver, and the junta fails that test in three ways. It enjoys little public support and governs a small share of the country. Any arrangement reached with it rests on a weak foundation. And its survival now depends on Beijing, which drives many of the junta's choices. In New Delhi, the general pledged to do "everything" to finish the long-stalled Kaladan project and the Trilateral Highway. He cannot. As Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri acknowledged, both are frozen in territory the junta does not control. The mass displacement that burdens India is a central objective of the military's "four cuts" strategy. Finally, a regime kept alive by Beijing's funding, weapons and diplomatic cover is not an instrument with which India can balance China.

The resistance is more unified than it has been at any point since the coup, offering India its most coherent alternative to Naypyidaw. Major resistance forces and the National Unity Government (NUG) recently established a single political and military body, the Steering Council for the Emergence of a Federal Democratic Union (SCEF). It brings together forces fielding well over 100,000 fighters, controls or contests close to half the country, and is fast becoming the actor most likely to shape Myanmar's future. India's interests are better served by engaging it now. The NUG and its allies do not ask India to break relations with Naypyidaw. The distinction India should draw is between formal recognition and functional partnership. The actors that can deliver results on border security, counter-narcotics, and infrastructure protection increasingly sit within the resistance.

India has spent decades building goodwill among its neighbours. It should not spend that capital on a regime that the Myanmar people are determined to remove.

The writer is representative to India of Myanmar's National Unity Government

The transition to a low-carbon economy could create millions of new jobs across manufacturing, engineering, construction, digital services and energy management sectors

The actors that can deliver results on border security, counter-narcotics, and infrastructure protection increasingly sit within the resistance

The Ideas Page

FRIDAY, JUNE 5, 2026

DIS/AGREE

THE BEST OF BOTH SIDES

A weekly column, which offers not this-versus-that, but the best of both sides, to inform the debate



ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

In aftermath of examination fiascos, what is the way forward for students, and the System?

It's a crisis of academic leadership



J S RAJPUT

INSTITUTIONS BUBBLING with energy, commitment, and ever-improving dynamic performance levels constitute the oasis of hope in democracies. The hopes and aspirations of the young are shaped by schools and institutions of higher education, which expand their horizons and synchronise their skills and interests, as well as by the care of their teachers. The best thing to happen after Independence was the creation of new institutions and the strengthening of existing ones. These were clearly statements of trust in the ingenuity of young Indians. Who is not proud of TIFR, BARC, ISRO, CSIR, and many more? The CBSE in its present form was created on July 1, 1962, the NCERT on September 1, 1961. Over the decades, both have acquired national and international credibility, acceptance, and appreciation, the credit for which must go to the leadership, exercise of autonomy, and a deep sense of “participating in creating the future of India” amongst the scholars and support staff. Unfortunately, the reputation of both has suffered in recent months and weeks.

Critical thinking is one of the very significant recommendations of the NEP, 2020. The NCERT did not showcase it when it published a chapter entitled “Corruption in Judiciary” in its Class VIII Social Science textbook. The Supreme Court was, rightly, furious. When it asked for the names of those responsible for the fiasco, the NCERT mentioned the names of three outside experts. That was unexpected for such a reputed organisation that has several hundred academics and teachers in its faculty. In every subject area, the responsibility should have been assigned to one or two internal faculty members. The SC put the three senior experts in a very embarrassing situation by banning them, without even listening to their version. This has, however, been corrected by the SC. The NCERT needs a serious rethink on this episode, which indicates a shirking of institutional responsibility. Consult experts, academics, teachers, and others, but every word published by the NCERT must be owned by the NCERT.

The CBSE fiasco is indeed painful. It has caused avoidable uncertainty, pain, and tension for millions of students and their families. The most critical transition in the lives of young learners takes place at the +2 stage. Every mark scored could make or mar their futures. The CBSE introduced On-Screen Marking (OSM) from this year for Class XII exams. It claims to have trained

evaluators, oriented principals, and even apprised the parents. If the reports indicating that a dry run was conducted less than a month before the examinations began are correct, it would amount to inadequate preparedness, lack of leadership, a shockingly inadequate institutional comprehension of its accountability to children and parents, and a dent to the CBSE's own image and credibility. Obviously, the ministry's consent would have been obtained. One could safely infer that if a serious academic analysis of the situation and the possible disastrous consequences of a failure had been conducted in an academic environment, the use of OSM would not have been implemented this year. Under no conditions should institutions like KVS, NVS, school boards, textbook corporations, and SCERTs be headed by bureaucrats.

The latest example of the NTA failing to learn from its earlier failures in conducting the NEET exam indicates a mere mechanical approach and an absence of corrective measures. The lack of concern and the absence of compassion for students were evident when the NTA chief, appearing before the parliamentary committee, refused to acknowledge any paper leak “through the system” and maintained that only a few questions were reported to have reached outside! Does it not amount to running away from moral responsibility? Umpteen such instances could be cited to underscore the need for academic leadership in institutions dealing with education, teachers, teacher training, and educational administration. Mere transfers and bringing in another person from the same clan are no solutions. It won't generate any confidence in the system, nor provide any solace to those suffering. Why should an institution like the National Institute for Educational Planning and Administration not be consulted in appointing heads of such institutions? If the backgrounds of the senior education ministry officials of the first two to three decades post-Independence, along with the heads of state-level educational bodies, were studied, it would indicate a large presence of academics. How was this changed, and by whom?

Acceptance of accountability and a commitment to enhancing institutional credibility are the country's expectations of every institution. Unfortunately, the failures of a couple of institutions within weeks of each other have disappointed not only students and their parents but also civil society. Are we so weak in managing things that the Prime Minister has to be bothered with monitoring the conduct of an examination? Should we go to the Air Force to assist the NTA? This is an unacceptable situation that needs a thorough overhaul.

The writer, former director of NCERT, works in education, social cohesion and religious amity

Rebuild confidence, tinkering won't do



KAUSHIK DAS GUPTA

AT LEAST three of the over 22 lakh students who appeared for the now-cancelled National Eligibility Cum Entrance Test (NEET) last month will not return to the examination hall when the test is conducted again later this month. The anguish and desperation of going through the gruelling process of preparation, reportedly, was too overwhelming, and they died by suicide. As the parents of one of these students told this newspaper, “This was his third NEET attempt. His exam had gone well. However, the news of the cancellation broke him from within.”

These unfortunate and extreme steps frame the challenge before policymakers in the wake of the cancellation of the entrance test to the country's medical institutions.

In a little over a month after the incident, government agencies have identified people who exploited the system's vulnerabilities and ran cheating operations. Meanwhile, the controversy surrounding the CBSE's rollout of its On-Screen Marking system has exposed another failure, rooted in institutional decision-making. Students alleged answer-sheet mismatches, blurred scans, unchecked responses, and evaluation anomalies, while reports, including in this newspaper, have pointed out that technical and operational concerns had been flagged during trial runs before the system was rolled out nationwide. Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan has admitted to moral responsibility for the failures. The Opposition has called for his resignation.

Identifying culpability and accepting responsibility are, of course, essential to preserving public trust in institutions. But too often the response is limited to addressing what went wrong in one examination cycle. The problem is that failures of various kinds recur across admissions processes and recruitment tests. Whether it's technical glitches, paper leaks, disputed evaluation mechanisms, logistical failures, or administrative lapses, the pattern now appears to be dispiritingly familiar — accountability usually ends at identifying a few rotten eggs, that too pushed by public outrage and censure from the country's highest court.

In the aftermath of a controversy over the evaluation of NEET answers, two years ago, the government was asked by the Supreme Court to constitute a high-level committee headed by former ISRO chief K Radhakrishnan to examine the functioning of the National Testing Agency (NTA) — the

body that conducts some of India's most consequential exams, including NEET — and recommend reforms. The committee's report pointed to inadequate institutional capacity, poor risk assessment, weak technological safeguards, insufficient accountability mechanisms, and the absence of a culture of continuous review. It recommended professionalising test administration, improving cybersecurity protocols, creating robust audit systems, and ensuring greater transparency in decision-making. A Parliamentary Standing Committee, too, has criticised the NTA for relying on private vendors and pointed out that firms black-listed in one state continue to operate in another. It should, therefore, not have required the cancellation of one of the country's most important entrance examinations, the despair of lakhs of students, and another Supreme Court intervention, to force the agency to acknowledge the problems that have been flagged repeatedly.

Examinations, of course, need to challenge the student's academic acumen. But the stress they pose to the youth in India stems primarily from the hyper-competitive environment they have to reckon with. For lakhs of young people, a handful of admission tests not only determine access to higher education and professional careers, but they are also gateways to social mobility. Students spend years preparing, many of them enduring the punishing processes of coaching centres, several families make financial sacrifices, and aspirations often get tied to scores in one examination. Uncertainty takes a toll on the student's morale. At a moment when young people are navigating one of the most consequential transitions in their lives, the state ought to be a source of reassurance. However, examination failures mean the costs of institutional incompetence are transferred onto those not even distantly responsible — and in some cases, as the suicides indicate, onto those least equipped to bear them.

For accountability to be meaningful, it has to begin with fixing responsibility for what went wrong, and then go further. The country's much-discussed demographic dividend can only be realised if millions of young people believe that education and perseverance will be rewarded fairly. Preventing the next paper leak, software glitch, evaluation error, or administrative lapse is, of course, of utmost importance. All that should be tied to an honest introspection into a milieu that appears to be creating despair — accountability should be about rebuilding confidence in institutions and creating an ecosystem that nurtures the aspirations of the youth, gives wings to their dreams, pushes them out of their comfort zone, but does not break them.

The writer is senior associate editor, The Indian Express. kaushik.dasgupta@expressindia.com

Magnifica Humanitas & MANAV: Creating a shared vision for AI



RAJEEV CHANDRASEKHAR

IN SPRING 2026, two influential world leaders addressed the age of artificial intelligence — and did so in strikingly similar terms. Pope Leo XIV's encyclical *Magnifica Humanitas: On Safeguarding the Human Person in the Time of Artificial Intelligence* (May 2026) is a major document of Catholic social teaching. It treats AI as a profound moral question, touching human dignity, truth, work, freedom, justice, peace, and the common good. Its central test is clear: Technology must be judged by what it does to the human person.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi (India AI Impact Summit, 2026 and the AI Action Summit, 2025), advanced the MANAV framework, a vision that closely converges with this: AI must be human-centric, ethical, inclusive, trusted, safe, and directed towards welfare for all. The traditions, vocabularies, and institutional settings differ. Yet the moral architecture is strikingly aligned.

There is convergence across seven dimensions. It is not an argument that the Pope and the PM have coordinated their thinking. Rather, it argues that serious moral reflection, across civilisational traditions, can arrive at shared truths when faced with a challenge as fundamental as AI: The human person must remain at the centre.

Human at the centre: The central convergence — the one from which all others flow — is the insistence that AI must remain centred on the human person, not the machine. Pope Leo XIV: “In the era of artificial intelligence, when human dignity is threatened by new forms of dehumanisation, ours is the pressing duty to remain profoundly human. We must lovingly safeguard the grandeur of humanity — the splendour of which no machine can ever replace.” PM Modi, at the India AI Impact Summit: “Technology exists to serve humanity, not to replace it.” At the Global summit, he underlined the core purpose of AI to “make it human-centric rather than machine-centric.”

AI for common good: Both leaders judge AI not by its technical sophistication but by whether it improves human lives and advances what the Catholic tradition calls the “common good” and what Indian philosophy calls *sarvajana hitaya* — the welfare of all. So the Pope talks about using technology to “identify new paths for the common good,” and the PM makes it clear that the “end goal of technology should be ‘Welfare for all, happiness for all.’”

The inequality warning: Both leaders warn, with unusual clarity, that AI could deepen the inequalities it promises to resolve — if access to data, compute, talent, and decision-making remains concentrated in a few hands. The Pope points to a “new imbalance” that can “divide, exclude and generate new forms of injustice”. The

PM's formulation is direct: “The more inclusive the development journey of AI, the more inclusive its results.”

The data-as-person danger: This is perhaps the strongest of the seven convergences — the one that most distinguishes both frameworks from purely technocratic approaches to AI governance. “AI must not reduce human beings to mere data points or raw material,” said the PM. The Pope urged avoiding the “pretence that a single language — even a digital one — can translate everything, including the mystery of the person, into data and performance”.

The hidden bias problem: On the question of algorithmic bias, both leaders display a sophistication that goes beyond the standard acknowledgement that bias is “a problem”. Both identify the specific mechanism — the appearance of neutrality — that makes AI bias particularly dangerous. For the Pope, the “exclusion of the vulnerable becomes cloaked in a veneer of neutrality and objectivity”. For the PM, the AI bias steeped in the Western context may not do justice to “our diversity, linguistic, cultural and regional”.

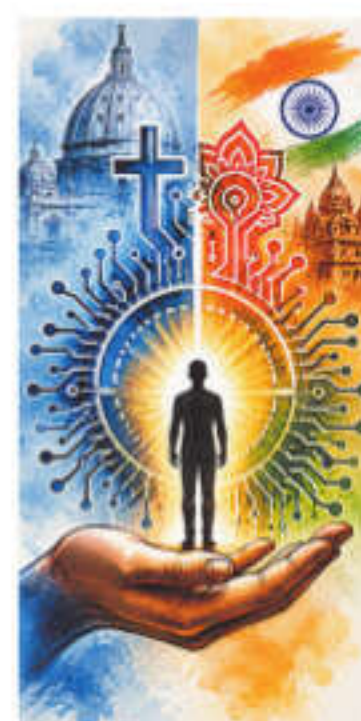
Work, dignity and the future of labour: Both leaders address directly the fear that most immediately shapes public anxiety about AI: The fear that it will destroy jobs, de-skill workers, and undermine the human dignity that comes from meaningful work. The PM strikes a hopeful note that history “has shown that work does not disappear due to technology... its nature changes and new jobs are created.” For the Pope, employment is basic to human dignity and needs to be protected.

Global governance and MANAV: Both leaders see AI governance as a shared human challenge — one that cannot be resolved by any single actor, nation, or tradition, and that requires ethical, participatory, and genuinely international frameworks. MANAV (M — Moral and Ethical Systems, A — Accountable Governance, N — National Sovereignty, A — Accessible and Inclusive, V — Valid and Legitimate) forms the cornerstone of the PM's vision for AI. The Pope warns against allowing a “handful of actors to dictate (AI) processes on their own.”

The convergence reflects a deeper truth: When serious moral traditions confront the same profound challenge, they often arrive at similar conclusions because certain truths about the human being are universal. It also affirms that the Global South must not remain a passive recipient of AI systems designed elsewhere, trained on data that does not reflect its realities, and governed by rules it did not help shape.

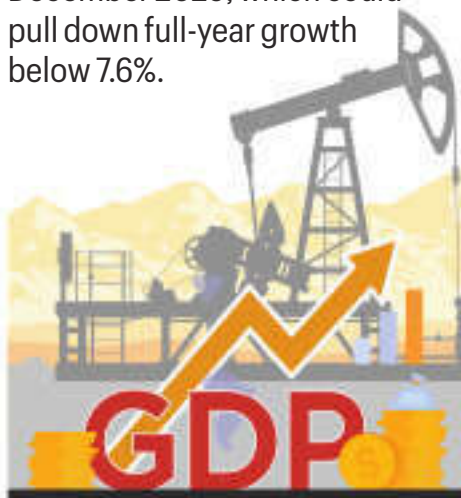
Most importantly, the moral resources for governing AI already exist — in Catholic social teaching, Indian philosophical tradition, and other civilisational ethics. The challenge is not to invent a new morality, but to bring existing wisdom to bear on the decisions shaping AI's future. Pope Leo XIV and Prime Minister Modi have each made that wisdom available. AI developers, investors, and policymakers must listen.

The writer is president, BJP Kerala, and former minister of state, Electronics & IT, Skill Development and Entrepreneurship and Jal Shakti

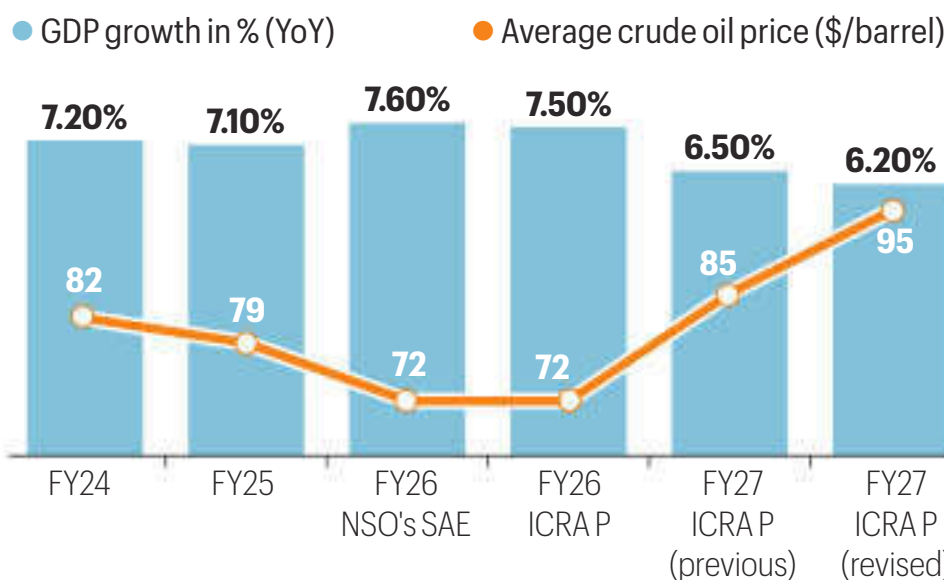


• RBI's growth, inflation forecasts are under threat

At 10 am today, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra will announce the Monetary Policy Committee's interest rate decision, just six hours before the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) releases GDP data for January-March and the provisional estimate for FY26. Back in February, MoSPI's second advance estimate had pegged the full-year growth at 7.6%. But with the war in West Asia overlapping with a third of the final quarter of the year, economists see economic activity having taken some hit and fall to around 7% in January-March from 7.8% in October-December 2025, which could pull down full-year growth below 7.6%.



Annual trends in GDP growth (at constant 2022-23 prices) and average crude oil prices



P: PROJECTED; SAE: SECOND ADVANCE ESTIMATES; SOURCE: NSO, PPAC, ICRA RESEARCH

• Whatever the FY26 GDP growth figure, the RBI's eye will now be on FY27, for which it had predicted a growth rate of 6.9% back in April. Retail inflation, meanwhile, was seen averaging 4.6%. Both these forecasts are now under threat.

• While the likes of Barclays and Nomura expect the RBI to lower its FY27 GDP growth forecast by 10-20 bps and raise the inflation projection close to 5%, others like ICRA see growth potentially falling to as much as 6.2% in the current fiscal, assuming crude oil prices average \$95 per barrel.

Centre appoints Neelkanth Mishra as World Bank Executive Director

New Delhi: The Union government on Thursday appointed economist Neelkanth Mishra as Executive Director, World Bank headquarters in Washington DC, replacing former NITI Aayog chairman Parameswaran Iyer. The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet approved Mishra's three-year tenure, starting from the date he assumes office or until further

orders. He is a member of the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister and Chief Economist at Axis Bank. He has been the MD and Co-Head of Equity Strategy, Asia Pacific, and India Strategist for Credit Suisse.

"He has been rated among the best analysts in India by the Institutional Investor and Asia Money polls. He is part of the Advisory Council to the

Fifteenth Finance Commission, and has been an advisor to committees appointed by the Government of India — such as the RNR Committee on GST and the FRBM Review Committee," the EAC-PM website says.

In another decision, the ACC on Thursday approved a one-year extension for Advisor to PM Tarun Kapoor. **ENS**

• DIPLOMACY

Old ties, new Nepal: What India needs to negotiate



SHUBHAJIT ROY

THE CHIEF of Nepal’s ruling Rastriya Swatantrata Party (RSP), Rabi Lamichhane, met Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday as part of his ongoing India visit.

This is the highest-level visit from Nepal since the RSP swept to power in March this year, with rapper-turned-politician Balendra Shah assuming the top office on the back of the Gen Z protests.

While many tried to draw parallels between the political situation in Nepal and Bangladesh after the youth-led protests, they were different on one major account: in Nepal, the mainstream political parties made sure elections took place within six months of the fall of the KP Sharma Oli government.

RSP and India

New Delhi has been used to dealing with the traditional, long-term actors and partners in Nepal’s politics, who took turns forming the government.

But, under Shah, the median age of Nepal’s parliament has dropped. According to reports, almost 38 per cent of Nepal’s lawmakers are younger than 40, a direct outcome of the Gen Z movement.

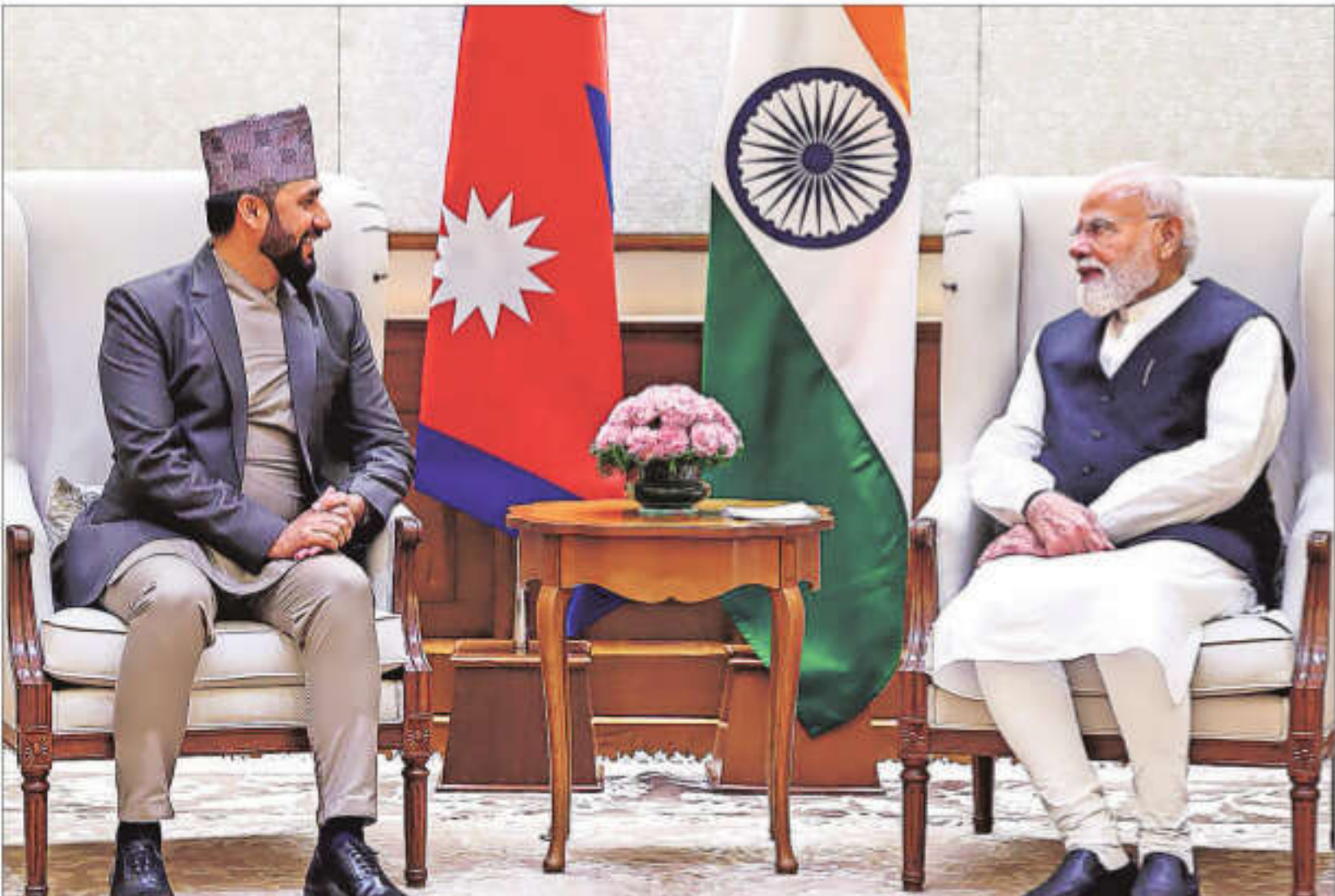
Shah — a first-time MP — is the Prime Minister and is challenging the norms from the beginning.

On the diplomatic front, he has declared he will not meet officials and ministers below his rank, and thus will only meet heads of states and governments. He has also said he will not undertake any foreign trip in the first one year, as he wants to focus on the domestic governance agenda.

As a result, he has met foreign ambassadors in groups, including the Indian ambassador in Kathmandu. He did not meet the visiting US ambassador to India, Sergio Gor, who also wears the hat of South and Central Asian envoy of the US.

Since he was not meeting any senior official one-on-one, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri — who was supposed to travel to Nepal last month — did not travel to Kathmandu.

If Misri would have met Shah, he would have extended an invitation on behalf of PM Narendra Modi to visit India. But since



PM Narendra Modi with Rabi Lamichhane, chief of Nepal’s ruling Rastriya Swatantra Party, in New Delhi, Wednesday.

Shah has put a self-imposed ban on foreign travel, that invitation did not materialise.

India has traditionally been the first overseas stop for Nepal’s Prime Ministers. The visit usually happens quite early in their term.

Since the establishment from both sides felt a diplomatic deadlock setting in, they decided to unlock it with a visit by Lamichhane — the second-most powerful political leader in Nepal. Lamichhane was invited by the BJP for a political party-level engagement, to unlock the diplomatic doors.

PM Modi met him in that context and conveyed that Nepal is India’s “priority partner” and that New Delhi is looking forward to collaborating with the new government to take the bilateral relationship to “greater heights”.

While External Affairs minister S Jaishankar also met Lamichhane, what stood out was his meeting with Home minister Amit Shah. Normally, Shah doesn’t meet foreign leaders and envoys.

Nepal’s Foreign minister, Shishir Khanal, also lands today.

Balen’s ‘encroachment’ remark

Lamichhane’s visit takes place days after PM Shah said that Nepal had “en-

The man in power

India is used to dealing with the traditional, long-term actors and partners in Nepal’s politics.

PM Balen Shah, a first-time MP, is challenging the old norms. He has declared he will not meet officials and ministers below his rank, and will only meet heads of state.

croached” on Indian territories, and sought involvement of China and the United Kingdom to address the long-standing dispute.

Even as the visit was ongoing, India on Tuesday categorically rejected any role for third parties to resolve its boundary row with Nepal.

Lamichhane’s post, after meeting PM Modi, displayed his political maturity. Without mentioning anything on the border dispute, he said that it was a great delight to engage in “a productive hour-long conversation” with Modi.

“I share your vision for a future where Nepal and India transcend past constraints to embrace a new era of development diplomacy. By focusing on shared civilization bonds, digital corridors, and seamless connectivity, we can truly build a partnership defined by progress and mutual trust. RSP looks forward to translating these possibilities into reality for people of Nepal and India—for our shared prosperity,” Lamichhane wrote.

This demonstrates the path of “development diplomacy” that the new Nepal government is focussed on where “digital corridors” via the UPI and other payment mechanisms to “seamless connectivity” via road, rail and air routes will be strengthened.

Some in Nepal see India as a bullying big brother. New Delhi must not allow Beijing to fan these flames among the Nepalese youth

Big brother vs elder brother

The diplomatic challenge in dealing with the new Nepal is that Delhi is seen by some sections as a “bully”.

The political actions and statements from India in 2015 alienated a vast section of the Nepalese population. This was when the Nepalese Constitution was being drafted, and India criticised it for not giving enough rights to Madhesi, who share community links on the Indian side of the border. There was also an unofficial, deeply unpopular months-long blockade of the India-Nepal border in Bihar.

India, on its part, has sought to project itself as a benevolent “elder brother”, as then External Affairs minister Sushma Swaraj had once described, instead of “big brother”, an epithet used for bullying behaviour.

Delhi feels that the ties are too strong to be overlooked. South Block says that India remains Nepal’s largest trade partner, about 80 lakh Nepalese citizens live and work in India, and around 6 lakh Indians live in Nepal. Indians account for about 30 per cent of foreign tourists in Nepal. The bilateral remittance flow is estimated at about US\$ 3 billion (Nepal to India) and \$1 billion (India to Nepal).

The China factor

There is also a geopolitical contest for influence playing out in Kathmandu.

The Himalayan country finds itself sandwiched between the two powers, India and China, and Nepalese political leadership has in the past sought to use the China card with India. The US too is active and has been interested in being part of the landscape there.

Delhi is watching how the new Kathmandu navigates Beijing’s moves, which is trying to play a more influential role in Nepal’s domestic affairs. In fact, the former Chinese ambassador to Nepal is currently the head of the border division in the Chinese Foreign ministry.

Shah needs to stabilise Nepal’s economy, undertake reforms, crack down on corruption and build infrastructure. India has agreed to step up its cooperation in all these areas. India’s development and economic aid must remain open.

Delhi’s position on the politics and future of Nepal has to remain nuanced, so that Beijing doesn’t get an opportunity to fan the suspicion of India being a bully or a big brother. India should remain an elder brother, or better still, an equal partner.

• LEGAL

Can insolvency process pause cheque bounce cases? SC to rule

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, June 4

IF A person enters insolvency proceedings, can a cheque bounce case against them be put on hold?

The Supreme Court has now set the stage for a clear ruling on this matter. It has referred to a larger bench the question of how the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), which provides a debt resolution framework, intersects with Section 138 of the Negotiable Instruments Act, which criminalises cheque bouncing.

On May 29, a bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and KV Viswanathan said a distinction may have to be drawn between the criminal and compensatory aspects of the cheque bounce litigation. The IBC, they observed, cannot become a route to avoid personal criminal accountability. They also said that allowing the recovery of compensation in a cheque bounce case during insolvency proceedings could undermine the IBC’s objective of ensuring orderly distribution of assets among creditors.

The reference stems from a conflict in the court’s own jurisprudence — whether a bounced cheque is a criminal matter or a “civil sheep in criminal wolf’s clothing”.

What the IBC says

When a person is undergoing personal insolvency proceedings under the IBC, a moratorium on legal action or proceedings in respect of any debt kicks in.

The current case, *Dineshchand Surana v. UCO Bank*, pertained to whether a cheque bounce case qualifies as a proceeding that can be paused by the insolvency process. If so, this would change the calculus for creditors,

accused persons and directors of companies who are simultaneously facing insolvency and Negotiable Instruments Act proceedings.

What is Section 138?

Section 138 makes dishonouring a cheque a criminal offence punishable by imprisonment, a fine or both. The criminal deterrent is meant to enhance people’s faith in cheques as a mode of payment.

Over time, courts placed emphasis on the compensatory aspect of Section 138 proceedings. A convicted accused can be directed to pay compensation. The offence is compoundable, which means that the parties can settle, and the case ends. A complainant can simultaneously file a civil suit for the same amount. These features have led courts to treat Section 138 proceedings as serving a dual purpose: punishment and restitution.

It is this dual character that makes the interaction with insolvency law complicated.

The IBC moratorium is designed to prevent actions that deplete a debtor’s assets while a restructuring is underway. If a compensatory part of a Section 138 proceeding does exactly that, taking money out of the debtor’s estate in favour of the creditor, it may fall within the moratorium’s reach. But if the offence is primarily criminal, the moratorium has no business touching it.

The conflict in legal precedent

The conflict in precedent goes back to a 2021 three-judge ruling in *P Mohanraj v. Shah Bros Ispat*, which dealt with the corporate insolvency moratorium. That bench described Section 138 as “a civil sheep in criminal wolf’s clothing”. This meant that despite the criminal form of the section, its real purpose was to recover money. By that reading, a moratorium on legal action in respect of debt would logically extend to a complaint under Section 138. But in 2025, a two-judge bench (*Rakesh Bhanot v. Gurdas Agro*) held that allowing accused persons to invoke a moratorium to avoid Section 138 prosecution would undermine the Negotiable Instruments Act. The bench said the moratorium was meant to postpone civil actions to recover debt, not stall criminal prosecution.

Neither ruling resolved the conflict cleanly. Now the matter has been placed before the Chief Justice of India for the formation of an appropriate bench.

• INFRASTRUCTURE

Congestion, resources, rules: Why residential areas are more vulnerable to fire

Anil Sasi
New Delhi, June 4

THE DEADLY blaze in South Delhi on Wednesday has brought back into focus the numerous fire safety gaps in India’s urban areas — including the absence of a culture of fire preparedness and the lack of institutional support in responding to an incident.

While the number of fire-related incidents and fatalities have broadly been coming down over the years (*see chart*), the single striking feature is that residential areas continue to be, by far, the single largest source of fire-linked fatalities in India, shows official data.

A key reason behind residential and commercial fires, especially in urban centres, is the lack of compliance with building by-laws and planning norms. Indeed, Wednesday’s fire in the densely populated Malviya Nagar took place at a hotel that was originally a residential structure but had been extensively expanded. A look at why urban areas, particularly

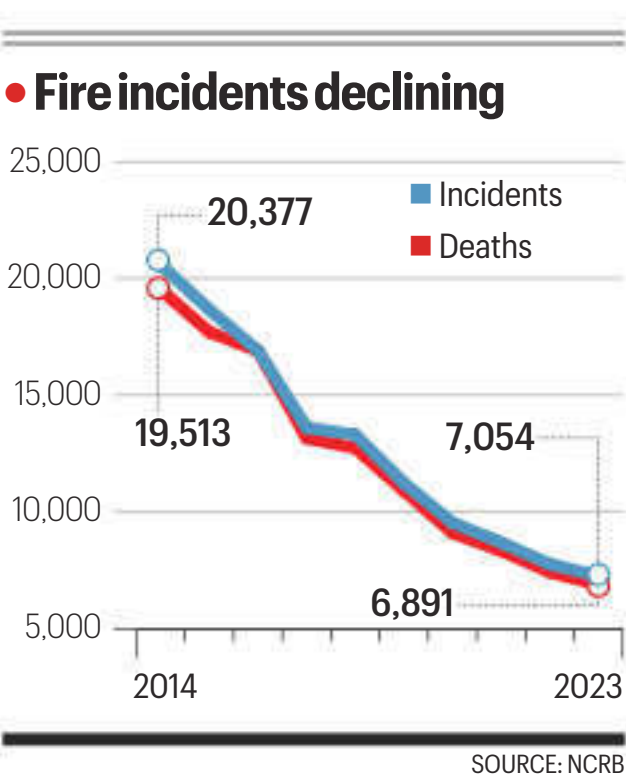
residential structures, in the country have been particularly vulnerable to fires.

60% of fire deaths in residential buildings

Out of every ten documented fire-related deaths in India in 2024, six occurred in residential or dwelling buildings, according to an analysis of the 2024 National Crime Records Bureau report by Beyond Carlton, a Bengaluru-based non-profit focused on fire safety. That year, 5,888 fire-related deaths were recorded nationally, and about 3,555 happened inside homes and residential buildings.

That’s partly because unlike purely commercial buildings, most residential spaces in India continue to operate without smoke alarms, suppression systems, evacuation planning or routine safety awareness.

In many areas of Delhi, for instance, several homeowners have converted their residential properties into bed & breakfast establishments, often flouting rules. In the case of Flourish Stays B&B, the structure



that caught fire, the owner had increased the number of rooms from six to 26, spread across six levels. The building also did not have any fire NOC (no-objection certificate). “Cities need a fire plan — where multiple stakeholders are alert and ac-

countable,” Cheryl Rebello, CEO, Beyond Carlton, told *The Indian Express*.

The highest incidents of fire-linked casualties in non-residential buildings are the ones reported from hospitals and bustling commercial areas such as shopping centres.

Fire services a state subject

Fire services are technically a state subject and have been included as a municipal function in the XII Schedule of the Constitution under Article 243 (W).

While the Centre largely has an advisory role in this, the Bureau of Indian Standards in 2016 published the National Building Code of India (NBC) that covered detailed guidelines for construction, maintenance and fire safety of buildings and structures.

The latest version of the NBC, from 2016, includes aspects such as smoke management, periodic audits, electrical fire prevention, building management systems, sensors for firefighting and fire prevention. The problem, however, lies in implementation of all these regulations, as seems to

be the case in the Delhi fire. According to officials, it was triggered by a short circuit.

Besides electrical faults, the trigger for most residential fires is a gas leak.

Urban fires

Fire is one of the most common risks worldwide and has been identified as one of the major hazards in the United Nation Global Assessment Report 2018.

Its side effects are deadly too. “It depletes oxygen from the surrounding event and most of the victims in a fire die of asphyxiation due to smoke and lack of oxygen. Then there could be the release of toxic gases from burning of materials due to fire that cause choking of lungs and breathing problems for the victims. In addition, the heating effect of fire results in expansion of liquids, gases and various metals, which often lead to explosions and bursts”, according to the National Institute of Disaster Management (NIDM).

Resource constraint has been a problem in tackling triggers of fire, especially in urban

areas. The Fifteenth Finance Commission, while noting lack of resources and equipment for the fire services in the country and recognising the need for expansion and modernisation of fire services, has recommended a provision of Rs 5,000 crore for strengthening fire services at the state level.

The high density of urban settlements resulting in narrow and constricted circulation spaces also add to the urban fire vulnerabilities, according to the NIDM.

The high use of electrical equipment and machinery in urban areas leads to higher chances of faulty electric connections and gadget failures amplifies the risks further.

Urban fires therefore occur in complex risk settings, with one or more factors coming into play simultaneously. According to an earlier report by the Ministry of Home Affairs (2022), there is “a considerable gap in operational capabilities of fire and emergency services in Indian cities”. Growing high-rises in urban areas further necessitate procurement of specialised equipment for fire fighting, which is slow to come by.